

# Inflation relative price variance

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# 1 Introduction

Inflation is known to have adverse welfare effects through its distortion of relative prices which causes the misallocation of resources, production inefficiencies leading to lower real economic activity. This is well supported by both theoretical and empirical studies. This paper contributes to the empirical literature, by examining the relationship between inflation and relative price variability (RPV) in South Africa given the little evidence available and to better understand how this relationship has evolved and the implications for monetary policy.

The South African context can provide further insights into the relationship between inflation and RPV given the shifts in the inflation targets from 3- 6 per cent in 2000 to 4.5 per cent since 2017 as structural changes in inflation can affect the link between inflation and relative price variability (Caglayan and Filiztekin, 2003) and that the functional form of relationship is U-shaped and dynamic (Fielding and Mizen, 2000; Choi, 2010). The latter motivates the estimation of the inflation rate that minimizes relative price distortions since if the relationship was linear then the optimal inflation rate would be zero. Given the inflation target reform towards a 3% in South Africa, this study contributes to the policy discussion on the appropriate inflation target and understating how dynamic relations between inflation and relative price variability has evolved.

The theoretical literature generally distinguishes between menu-cost and signal extraction models in explaining the positive relation between trend inflation and RVP. In these models' firms follow a one-sided dynamic pricing rule when setting prices and face fixed non-zero costs of adjusting nominal prices (e.g. printing new menus) when inflation increases as the latter reduces the optimal real price of goods and services. Due to differences in administrative costs, these nominal price adjustment costs vary across firms moreover these adjustments occur at different times which implies staggered price setting behaviour which leads to relative price variability. Menu cost models predict a that higher expected inflation causes an increase in RVP (citations xxx) while Lucas-type signal extraction models (Lucas(1973); Hercowitz (1981); Cukierman (1984) xxxx more citations) argue unexpected inflation uncertainty causes higher RVP because informational frictions make it difficult to distinguish between idiosyncratic relative shocks or

an aggregate (inflationary) shock. Menu cost and signal-extraction models assume a positive and linear relationship making the optimal inflation rate zero, however, recently monetary search models (Head and Kumar, 2005) show that this relationship is nonlinear making the optimal inflation rate somewhere between zero and positive inflation rate.

## 2 Citations

Adam et al. (2024) Baglan et al. (2016) Ball and Romer (1993) Benabou and Gertner (1993) Caglayan and Filiztekin (2003) Caglayan et al. (2008) Grier and Perry (1996) Lach and Tsiddon (1992) Nakamura et al. (2018) Ndou and Redford (2014) Ndou and Gumata (2017) Parks (1978) Parsley (1996) Rather et al. (2018)

## 3 Literature review

## 4 Data and methodology

Our analysis uses monthly inflation data on 45 goods categories from January 2009 to March 2025 obtained from Statistics South Africa (Stats SA).<sup>1</sup> **The data is seasonally adjusted using ???.** Figure 1 below shows the long term inflation rate in South Africa, and Figure A1 in the appendix shows the various price categories used in the analysis. Table A1 provides the descriptive statistics of the inflation rates for the various price categories used in the analysis.

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<sup>1</sup><http://www.statssa.gov.za/>

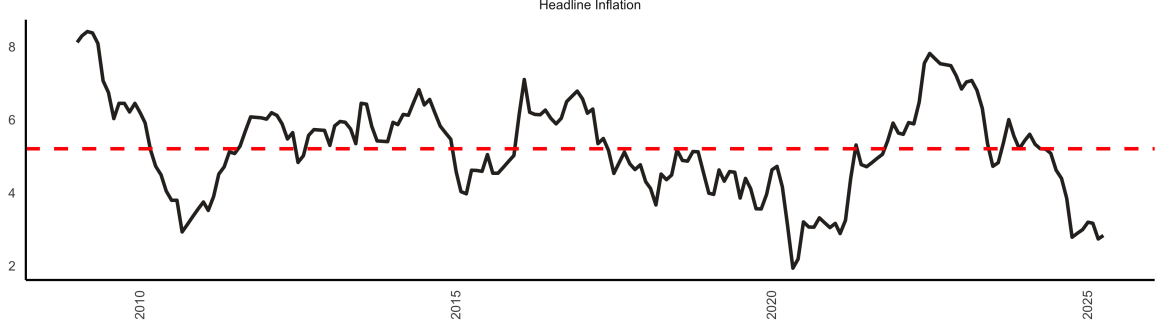


Figure 1: Headline inflation. Note: The dashed red line is the average inflation over the period.

The relative price variance (RPV) is calculated in line with [Lach and Tsiddon \(1992\)](#) as the weighted standard deviation of individual price inflation rates from the aggregate inflation rate. The RPV is essentially the variability of relative prices of a given product. We first calculate the monthly inflation rate as follows:

$$\pi_{i,t} = \ln \left( \frac{P_{i,t}}{P_{i,t-1}} \right) * 100, \quad (1)$$

where  $\pi_{i,t}$  is the inflation rate of good  $i$  at time  $t$ ,  $P_{i,t}$  is the price of good  $i$  at time  $t$ , and  $P_{i,t-1}$  is the price of good  $i$  at time  $t - 1$ . Then, the RPV is calculated as:

$$RPV_{i,t} = \sqrt{\sum_{i=1}^n \omega_i (\pi_{i,t} - \pi_t)^2}, \quad (2)$$

where  $\omega_j$  is the expenditure share of the  $j^{th}$  good,  $\pi_t$  is the headline or aggregate inflation rate at time  $t$ , and  $\sum_{i=1}^n \omega_i = 1$ . The expenditure weights ( $\omega_i$ ) used are derived from the Consumer Price Index (CPI) basket provided by Stats SA. Figure 2 shows the RPV calculated using the above formula. **When where these weights constructed???** The weights are shown in Figure A2 in the appendix.

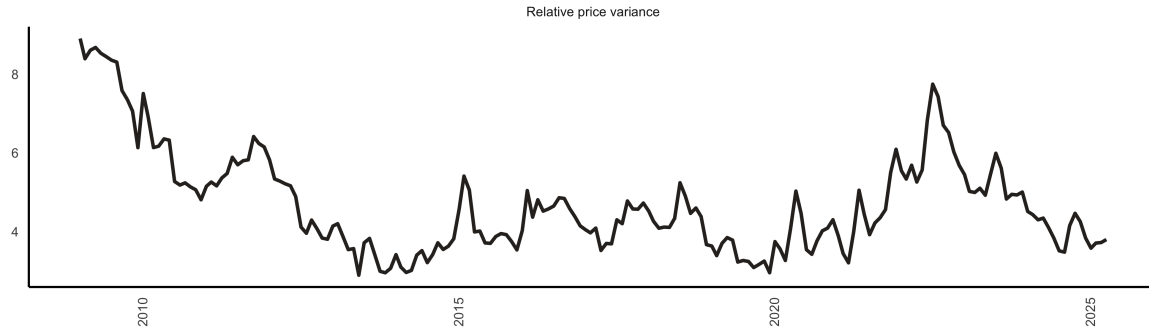


Figure 2: Relative price variance

To examine the relationship between inflation and RPV, we estimate the following econometric model:

$$RPV_{i,t} = \alpha_i + \mu_{i,t} \quad (3)$$

where  $\alpha_i$  is the constant term and  $\mu_{i,t}$  is the error term.

## 5 Results

## 6 Conclusion

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# A Appendix

## A.1 Data

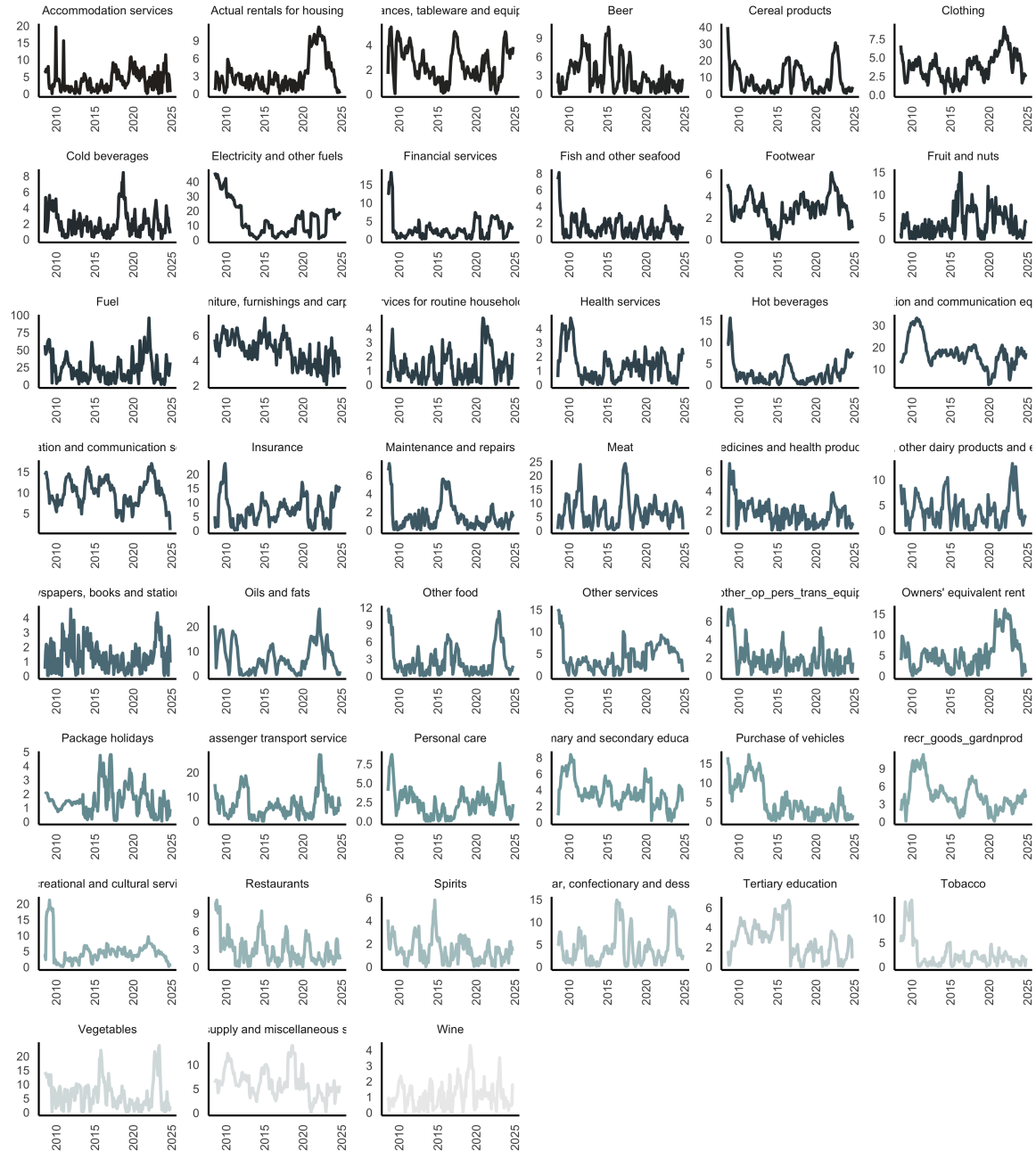


Figure A1: Good categories inflation

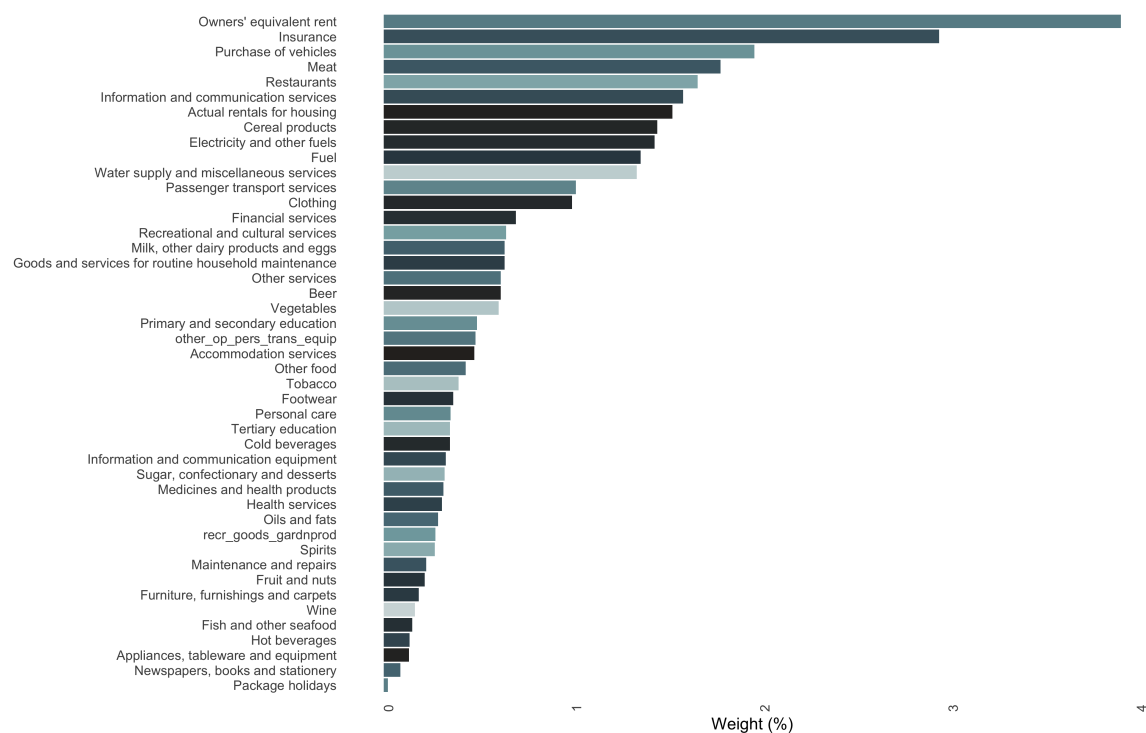


Figure A2: CPI Weights. Note: Due to a lack of data, some categories (no spirits; transport services of goods; household textiles; glassware,tableware, and house utensils; and Tools and equipment for house and garden) have been excluded.

## A.2 Descriptive statistics

Table A1: Descriptive statistics

| Goods category                                       | Mean  | Median | SD    | Min  | Max   | Observations |
|------------------------------------------------------|-------|--------|-------|------|-------|--------------|
| Accommodation services                               | 3.69  | 2.97   | 2.96  | 0.02 | 19.60 | 196          |
| Actual rentals for housing                           | 3.19  | 2.39   | 2.73  | 0.04 | 11.28 | 196          |
| Appliances, tableware and equipment                  | 2.40  | 2.13   | 1.35  | 0.03 | 5.47  | 196          |
| Beer                                                 | 2.97  | 2.04   | 2.53  | 0.01 | 10.77 | 196          |
| Cereal products                                      | 8.33  | 4.98   | 7.98  | 0.01 | 40.01 | 196          |
| Clothing                                             | 3.74  | 3.61   | 1.78  | 0.17 | 9.09  | 196          |
| Cold beverages                                       | 2.01  | 1.62   | 1.57  | 0.04 | 8.45  | 196          |
| Electricity and other fuels                          | 13.98 | 10.03  | 11.77 | 0.53 | 46.31 | 196          |
| Financial services                                   | 2.76  | 1.97   | 3.14  | 0.02 | 18.30 | 196          |
| Fish and other seafood                               | 1.46  | 1.15   | 1.24  | 0.01 | 8.09  | 196          |
| Footwear                                             | 2.84  | 2.87   | 1.22  | 0.03 | 6.13  | 196          |
| Fruit and nuts                                       | 3.69  | 2.99   | 3.07  | 0.02 | 14.90 | 196          |
| Fuel                                                 | 22.89 | 18.12  | 18.11 | 0.13 | 95.60 | 196          |
| Furniture, furnishings and carpets                   | 4.77  | 4.80   | 1.08  | 2.07 | 7.39  | 196          |
| Goods and services for routine household maintenance | 1.25  | 0.97   | 1.05  | 0.00 | 4.71  | 196          |
| Health services                                      | 1.37  | 1.24   | 1.10  | 0.00 | 4.75  | 196          |
| Hot beverages                                        | 2.74  | 1.94   | 2.75  | 0.03 | 15.61 | 196          |
| Information and communication equipment              | 17.26 | 16.87  | 6.42  | 2.86 | 33.39 | 196          |
| Information and communication services               | 10.04 | 10.12  | 3.25  | 0.91 | 16.99 | 196          |
| Insurance                                            | 7.27  | 7.10   | 4.85  | 0.12 | 23.75 | 196          |
| Maintenance and repairs                              | 1.51  | 1.09   | 1.53  | 0.01 | 7.29  | 196          |
| Meat                                                 | 7.12  | 6.30   | 5.30  | 0.15 | 24.32 | 196          |
| Medicines and health products                        | 1.72  | 1.54   | 1.26  | 0.01 | 6.79  | 196          |
| Milk, other dairy products and eggs                  | 3.99  | 3.64   | 2.81  | 0.05 | 13.17 | 196          |
| Newspapers, books and stationery                     | 1.31  | 1.11   | 1.00  | 0.02 | 4.59  | 196          |
| Oils and fats                                        | 7.39  | 6.15   | 5.99  | 0.00 | 27.17 | 196          |
| Other food                                           | 2.67  | 1.70   | 2.74  | 0.06 | 11.73 | 196          |
| Other services                                       | 4.15  | 3.19   | 3.07  | 0.00 | 15.10 | 196          |
| Owners' equivalent rent                              | 5.29  | 4.75   | 3.98  | 0.01 | 16.18 | 196          |
| Package holidays                                     | 1.55  | 1.40   | 1.00  | 0.04 | 4.80  | 196          |
| Passenger transport services                         | 6.74  | 5.40   | 5.36  | 0.00 | 27.30 | 196          |
| Personal care                                        | 2.44  | 2.33   | 1.77  | 0.01 | 8.72  | 196          |
| Primary and secondary education                      | 3.60  | 3.39   | 1.69  | 0.13 | 8.37  | 196          |
| Purchase of vehicles                                 | 5.22  | 3.33   | 4.67  | 0.08 | 17.30 | 196          |
| Recreational and cultural services                   | 4.75  | 4.05   | 3.89  | 0.07 | 21.16 | 196          |
| Restaurants                                          | 2.91  | 2.29   | 2.42  | 0.07 | 11.17 | 196          |
| Spirits                                              | 1.43  | 1.30   | 1.04  | 0.00 | 5.80  | 196          |
| Sugar, confectionary and desserts                    | 4.18  | 3.18   | 3.75  | 0.03 | 14.87 | 196          |
| Tertiary education                                   | 2.61  | 2.50   | 1.71  | 0.02 | 6.78  | 196          |
| Tobacco                                              | 2.41  | 1.57   | 2.89  | 0.01 | 13.75 | 196          |
| Vegetables                                           | 6.35  | 5.05   | 5.12  | 0.00 | 23.81 | 196          |
| Water supply and miscellaneous services              | 6.16  | 5.77   | 2.83  | 0.15 | 13.91 | 196          |
| Wine                                                 | 1.13  | 0.98   | 0.83  | 0.03 | 4.28  | 196          |
| other_op_pers_trans Equip                            | 1.85  | 1.44   | 1.58  | 0.00 | 7.33  | 196          |
| recr_goods_gardnprod                                 | 4.39  | 3.86   | 2.56  | 0.06 | 11.34 | 196          |

### A.3 Alternative Results

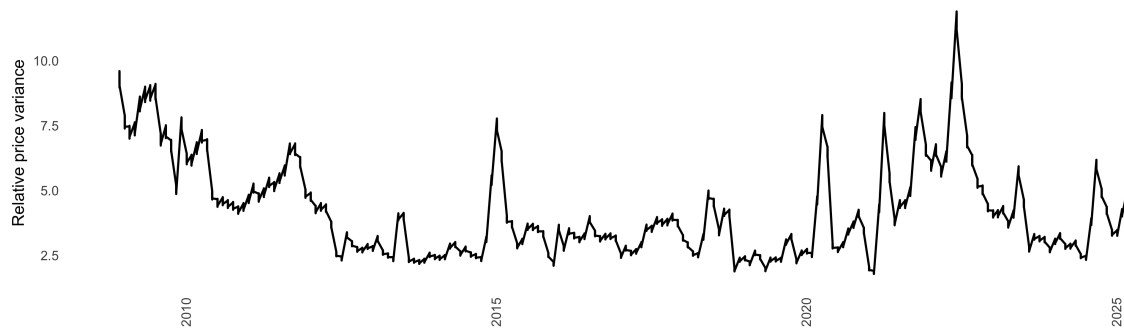


Figure A3: Coefficient of variation version of RPV